

SHK as the beachhead: grounded knowledge before anything else

Why Germany's most fragmented, most legally volatile trade is where a CraftHub should start — and what the live build (Stichtag) proves about that bet.

Prepared for Sebastian Johnston, CITO · 27 Aug 2026 · Live: [shk-hub.vercel.app](#) ·
Repo: [github.com/tfortito/Shk-Hub](#)

48,050 SHK trade businesses in Germany, 2024 ^[1]	388,334 People employed in the SHK trade ^[1]
€59.1bn Industry revenue, 2025 ^[2]	2 law changes in 30 days: GModG + BEG funding reset, July 2026 ^[3,4]

WHY SHK

SHK — plumbing, heating, air conditioning — is large, deeply fragmented, and acutely underserved: **48,050 businesses**^[1], mostly Meister-led (master-craftsman-owned), averaging roughly 8 employees, with no DATEV-equivalent centralizing knowledge or communication. Unlike tax advisors, SHK just lived through two real legal changes in one month: the GModG dropped the mandatory 65% renewables rule^[3], and BEG subsidy rates dropped immediately and keep stepping down every six months^[4].

ICP: Meister-led SHK business, 5–40 employees. Buying trigger: liability anxiety (a wrong funding number costs trust) plus sales pressure (faster, more confident quotes).

Willingness to pay (*assumption*): JUPUS charges roughly €200–300/month for a comparable AI-secretary bundle in law firms^[5]. SHK businesses already pay for Craftnote, ToolTime, Plancraft, STREIT^[6] — software spend is proven, but SHK billing rates sit below lawyers', so entry pricing needs to sit lower too.

Incumbent & gap: none of the established SHK tools offer a source-cited knowledge layer with validity dates. Plancraft already markets AI-drafted quotes^[6] — a signal, not a moat: Stichtag can be the trust layer underneath those tools, not a competitor on top of them.

WHAT SHIPS FIRST

The three CraftHub building blocks, in build order, not all at once:

- 01 Knowledge** (built, this case) — source-cited answers on law & funding. The cheapest trust proof, and the hardest for a generic chatbot to fake convincingly.
- 02 Workflow** (started) — from a drafted customer email to a real quote-text generator: the trade's actual core output.
- 03 Communication** (later) — phone/WhatsApp intake that captures a request and answers it against the knowledge layer. Pointless until that layer is trustworthy: an AI front desk quoting the wrong subsidy is worse than no AI front desk.

FIRST 30 DAYS

01

Ingest the real primary-source corpus: full Bundesgesetzblatt / BEG-Förderrichtlinie / KfW-Merkblatt PDFs instead of web-page summaries, plus 2–3 adjacent topics (heat-pump subsidy detail, hydraulic-balancing requirements, chimney-sweep certification).

02

Recruit 5 design-partner businesses via Innung/ZVSHK networks, free for 30 days for structured weekly feedback — validate real question patterns and willingness to pay before finalizing pricing.

03

Ship the quote-text generator plus a simple "hours saved" metric — turn the trust proof into a number that closes the sales conversation.

THREE HARDEST OBJECTIONS

"We already pay for Craftnote / Plancraft / STREIT — why another tool?"	Those tools speed up your existing workflow. Stichtag answers a different question: is what I'm about to tell this customer still true? That's not project management, that's liability — and it can run as the fact layer under your existing AI features, not beside them.
"AI hallucinates — how do I know it won't tell my customer something wrong, and I take the blame?"	That's the design, not an afterthought. It answers only from loaded documents, never from training knowledge, and declines when nothing is loaded. Every claim shows its source and validity date; when old and new law both surface, it says so instead of picking one silently. You're not trusting the AI's judgment — you're trusting that it can only quote what's actually on file, and you can check every citation yourself in one click.
"€39/month and setup time isn't worth it for a business our size."	One wrong funding figure costs you either the job (the customer finds a competitor with the current number) or the relationship (they signed on your number and it's no longer true) — that's more than a year of this tool. Setup is one link, no install, first answer in 30 seconds. The free trial exists so you don't have to take our word for it — test it on your hardest question before you pay anything.

[1] ZVSHK, "SHK-Handwerk 2025: Umsatz und Aufträge rückläufig" — zvshk.de

[2] ZVSHK press releases, 2024–2025 — zvshk.de

[3] Bundesregierung.de, "Neues Gebäudemodernisierungsgesetz"; Bundestag plenary record, KW28 2026

[4] KfW, product page "Heizungsförderung 458"; KfW press release, July 2026

[5] jupus.de, published pricing for the KI-Sekretariat bundle

[6] Craftnote.de; Plancraft product page; softwareabc24.de SHK software comparison

Points marked "assumption" are explicitly unverified — flagged rather than presented as fact, on purpose.

→ [Live app](#)

→ [Source repo](#)